

Why Do Leaves Change Color?

Key Terms

- sunlight
- photosynthesis
- chlorophyll
- sugar
- pigments

Trees need **sunlight**. Trees make their food from sunlight. This is called **photosynthesis**. Tree leaves have **chlorophyll**. Chlorophyll makes **sugar**. This helps the tree grow. Chlorophyll is green. There is more sunlight in the spring. There is more sunlight in the summer. This makes more chlorophyll. In the fall, the days get shorter. There is less sunlight. The tree makes less chlorophyll. Tree leaves have **pigments**. Pigments are colors. In the fall, the green pigment fades. The leaves change colors. The leaves turn orange, yellow, or red. Next, the leaves fall to the ground.

Making Connections

Trees, like plants, make their food from sunlight.



Interesting Facts:

- Pine and spruce trees stay green year-round.
- Trees store energy for the winter.
- Fall gets its name from falling leaves.

